Code of Ethics (ICN/ICM/Nigeria and Ethical Principles):

Ethics in nursing provides a moral foundation and guidelines for professional conduct, ensuring that nurses provide safe, competent, and compassionate care. The International Council of Nurses (ICN), the International Confederation of Midwives (ICM), and the Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN) have established codes of ethics that highlight core principles and responsibilities for nursing and midwifery professionals. These principles ensure that nurses uphold dignity, promote health, and advocate for patient rights.

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1. ICN Code of Ethics for Nurses

The **ICN Code of Ethics** serves as a global framework, emphasizing four principal responsibilities:

1. **To the Patient**:
    a. Respect patients' rights, dignity, and autonomy.
    b. Provide care without discrimination based on race, religion, gender, or socioeconomic status.
2. **To Practice**:
    a. Deliver safe, evidence-based, and compassionate care.
    b. Maintain competency through continuous education and professional development.

3. **To the Profession**:

    a. Uphold the integrity and values of the nursing profession.
    b. Advocate for ethical policies and practices in healthcare systems.

4. **To Co-workers**:

    a. Foster collaboration and respect within the healthcare team.
    b. Promote a supportive and ethical work environment.

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2. ICM Code of Ethics for Midwives

The **ICM Code of Ethics** outlines ethical conduct specific to midwifery:

1. **Respect for Human Dignity**:

✓ Provide care that respects the unique needs and rights of women and families.

2. **Advocacy**:

    a. Empower women to make informed decisions about their care.
    b. Actively advocate for policies that improve maternal and child health.

3. **Accountability**:

- ✓ Accept responsibility for professional actions and decisions.

4. **Confidentiality**:

- ✓ Protect patients' personal information unless disclosure is legally required.

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3. Nigerian Code of Ethics (NMCN)

The **Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria** (NMCN) emphasizes ethical standards that align with cultural and national contexts:

1. **Respect for Individuality**:

   Recognize the holistic nature of patients, considering their biological, psychological, social, and spiritual needs.

2. **Competency and Professionalism**:

   Ensure that nurses deliver competent care while adhering to the highest professional standards.

3. **Confidentiality**:

   Protect patient privacy and ensure confidentiality in all professional interactions.

4. **Advocacy**:

Serve as a voice for vulnerable populations and promote equitable healthcare.

5. **Accountability**:

Take responsibility for actions and continuously seek knowledge to improve practice.

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4. Ethical Principles in Nursing and Midwifery

Ethical principles guide nursing and midwifery practice:

1. **Autonomy**:

Respect patients' rights to make decisions about their care.

2. **Beneficence**:

Act in the best interest of patients to promote well-being.

3. **Non-Maleficence**:

Avoid causing harm to patients during care.

4. **Justice**:

Provide fair and equitable treatment to all patients.

5. **Fidelity**:

Uphold trust by being honest, reliable, and loyal to patients.

6. **Veracity**:

Ensure truthfulness and transparency in all communications.

7. **Confidentiality**:

Protect patient information and use it responsibly.

The codes of ethics from ICN, ICM, and NMCN, along with universal ethical principles, provide a comprehensive framework for nursing and midwifery professionals. These codes ensure that care is delivered with respect, integrity, and compassion while maintaining accountability and fostering trust between healthcare providers and patients.

Ethics and Standards of Practice in Nursing

Ethics and standards of practice in nursing provide guidelines for professional conduct, ensuring that nurses deliver safe, competent, and ethical care. These standards uphold patient rights, protect confidentiality, guide informed decision-making, and regulate legal and professional responsibilities. The core ethical principles, including **confidentiality, informed consent, care of patient properties, controlled substances, clinical trials, and legal documentation**, help maintain trust, accountability, and integrity in healthcare practice.

1. Confidentiality in Nursing Practice

Confidentiality is the ethical and legal obligation to protect patient information. It ensures that a patient's personal, medical, and health-related data is kept private and only shared with authorized personnel.

Key Principles of Confidentiality

- **Patient's Right to Privacy**: Nurses must not disclose patient information without consent, except in legally justified cases.
- **Access Control**: Only authorized healthcare professionals should access patient records.
- **HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act)** and **Data Protection Laws**: Govern the handling of patient data to prevent unauthorized access.
- **Exceptions to Confidentiality**:
  - If the patient is at risk of harming themselves or others.
  - Legal requirements such as reporting infectious diseases.
  - Court orders requiring disclosure.

Example: A nurse discussing a patient's condition in a public area violates confidentiality.

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2. Informed Consent

Informed consent is the process by which a patient voluntarily agrees to a medical procedure or treatment after understanding the risks, benefits, and alternatives.

Elements of Informed Consent

- **Competence**: The patient must be mentally capable of making a decision.
- **Disclosure**: The healthcare provider must explain the procedure, risks, and alternatives.
- **Understanding**: The patient should fully comprehend the information provided.
- **Voluntariness**: The decision must be made without coercion or pressure.
- **Consent Documentation**: The patient or legal representative must sign a consent form.

Types of Consent

- **Explicit Consent**: Verbal or written agreement (e.g., surgery or clinical trials).
- **Implied Consent**: Assumed based on a patient's actions (e.g., extending an arm for an injection).
- **Proxy Consent**: Given by a legal guardian if the patient is unable to decide (e.g., children, unconscious patients).

Example: A patient refusing a blood transfusion due to religious beliefs has the right to do so under informed consent.

3. Care of Patient's Properties

Nurses are responsible for safeguarding patients' personal belongings during their hospital stay.

Guidelines for Handling Patient Property

- **Documentation**: List and secure valuables upon admission.
- **Storage**: Keep valuable items in a hospital-designated safe if necessary.
- **Accountability**: Return belongings to the patient or family upon discharge.
- **Avoid Misplacement**: Always ensure that personal items such as dentures, eyeglasses, and mobility aids are safely kept.

Example: A nurse misplacing a patient's hearing aid can lead to distress and legal implications.

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4. Controlled Substances

Controlled substances are medications regulated due to their potential for abuse and dependence. Nurses play a crucial role in handling and administering these drugs safely.

Rules for Handling Controlled Substances

- **Proper Documentation**: Every dose administered must be recorded.
- **Storage and Security**: Kept in a locked, restricted-access area.

- **Double Verification**: Some high-risk drugs require two nurses to verify administration.
- **Disposal Regulations**: Expired or unused drugs must be disposed of according to hospital policy.

Examples of Controlled Substances

- Opioids (Morphine, Fentanyl)
- Benzodiazepines (Diazepam)
- Stimulants (Amphetamines)

Example: A nurse who administers a controlled substance without proper documentation may face legal action.

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5. Clinical Trials in Nursing

Clinical trials are research studies that test new treatments or drugs to determine their safety and effectiveness. Nurses play a vital role in ensuring ethical participation.

Ethical Considerations in Clinical Trials

- **Voluntary Participation**: Patients must not be forced or deceived into participation.
- **Informed Consent**: Patients must be fully aware of risks, benefits, and alternatives.
- **Confidentiality**: Personal data must be protected.
- **Monitoring and Reporting**: Any adverse effects must be documented and reported promptly.

Roles of Nurses in Clinical Trials

- Educating patients about the study.
- Monitoring for side effects.
- Ensuring adherence to research protocols.

Example: A nurse administering an experimental drug must ensure the patient understands the risks before participation.

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6. Signing of Legal Documents

Nurses may be required to witness or sign legal documents related to patient care, ensuring ethical and lawful medical practices.

Types of Legal Documents Nurses Handle

- **Advance Directives**: Instructions about a patient's preferred medical treatment in case they become incapacitated.
- **Do Not Resuscitate (DNR) Orders**: Legal orders stating that a patient should not receive CPR if their heart stops.
- **Consent Forms**: Signed agreements for surgical procedures, blood transfusions, or experimental treatments.
- **Incident Reports**: Documentation of errors, accidents, or unusual occurrences in healthcare settings.

Guidelines for Signing Legal Documents

- Ensure the patient understands the document before signing.
- Verify the identity of signatories.

- Do not sign on behalf of a patient unless legally authorized.
- Document any concerns in the patient's record.

Example: A nurse signing a consent form for a confused patient without verifying their understanding could lead to legal consequences.

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7. Factors Influencing Ethical Nursing Practice

Several factors can affect ethical decision-making in nursing, including:

1. **Cultural and Religious Beliefs**: Patient preferences may be influenced by their values and traditions.
2. **Hospital Policies**: Institutional rules and guidelines regulate nursing conduct.
3. **Legal Frameworks**: National laws and professional regulations must be followed.
4. **Personal Morality**: Nurses must align personal ethics with professional standards.
5. **Patient Rights**: Nurses must respect patients' autonomy and dignity.

Ethics and standards of practice in nursing provide a foundation for professional conduct, ensuring that patients receive safe, respectful, and competent care. Confidentiality, informed consent, proper handling of patient properties, controlled substances, clinical trials, and legal documentation are essential aspects of ethical nursing practice.

Adhering to these guidelines helps protect patients' rights, prevent legal issues, and maintain trust in the healthcare system

Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN) – Structure, Functions, and Regulations of Nursing Practice

The **Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)** is the regulatory body responsible for overseeing the education, training, registration, and professional conduct of nurses and midwives in Nigeria. It ensures that nursing and midwifery professionals adhere to ethical standards, maintain competency, and deliver high-quality healthcare services.

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1. Structure of the Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)

The **NMCN** operates under the **Federal Ministry of Health** and is governed by a structured hierarchy that oversees nursing and midwifery practice across Nigeria. The council consists of:

Governing Board:

1. Composed of representatives from various nursing and midwifery institutions, government agencies, and professional associations.
2. Responsible for policy formulation and overall regulation of the nursing profession.

Registrar/Secretary-General:

The administrative head of the council, overseeing daily operations, policy implementation, and enforcement of regulations.

Departments and Units:

1. **Education & Training**: Oversees curriculum development, accreditation of nursing schools, and training standards.
2. **Registration & Licensing**: Manages the registration and license of qualified nurses and midwives.
3. **Standards & Discipline**: Monitors adherence to ethical and professional standards, handling disciplinary cases.
4. **Continuing Professional Development (CPD)**: Ensures ongoing learning and professional growth for nurses and midwives.

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2. Functions of the Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)

The NMCN performs several key functions to regulate and advance nursing and midwifery practice in Nigeria:

Regulation of Nursing and Midwifery Education:

1. Establishes standards for training institutions.
2. Accredits nursing and midwifery schools.
3. Ensures uniformity in curriculum across all accredited institutions.

Registration and Licensure of Nurses and Midwives:

1. Administers licensure examinations for nursing and midwifery graduates.
2. Issues **practice licenses** to qualified professionals.
3. Maintains a registry of all licensed nurses and midwives in Nigeria.

Professional Regulation and Standards:

1. Develops and enforces the **Nursing Practice Act**.
2. Defines the **scope of practice** for different categories of nurses and midwives.
3. Establishes **codes of ethics** and professional conduct.

Disciplinary Actions and Enforcement:

1. Investigates complaints of **professional misconduct**.
2. Conducts disciplinary hearings and imposes sanctions, including suspension or revocation of licenses.
3. Ensures adherence to **patient care standards**.

Continuing Professional Development (CPD):

1. Mandates CPD programs to ensure nurses and midwives update their skills.
2. Organizes workshops, conferences, and specialized training programs.
3. Requires periodic re-license based on evidence of professional development.

Collaboration with Government and International Bodies:

1. Works with the **Federal Ministry of Health**, **hospitals**, and **universities** to improve healthcare services.
2. Engages with international bodies like the **International Council of Nurses (ICN)** and **World Health Organization (WHO)**.

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3. Regulations of Nursing Practice in Nigeria

Nursing practice in Nigeria is regulated through various **Decrees and Acts**, ensuring professionalism, accountability, and competency.

a. Nurse Practice Act/Decree

- The **Nurses and Midwives (Registration, etc.) Act Cap. N143** is the legal framework governing nursing and midwifery in Nigeria.
- Defines the roles and responsibilities of nurses and midwives.
- Establishes the legal backing for the **NMCN** to regulate nursing education and practice.

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b. Standard and Regulation of Training and Practice

The NMCN ensures that training institutions adhere to approved education and practice standards:

Accreditation of Schools:

- Nursing and midwifery schools must meet the minimum requirements set by the **NMCN.**
- Institutions are subject to regular evaluation and accreditation reviews.

Standardized Curriculum:

- A **uniform curriculum** is implemented across all accredited institutions.
- Training programs include **theoretical learning, clinical practice, and ethical training**.

Scope of Practice:

- The **NMCN** defines the scope of practice for different nursing cadres:
  - **General Nurses**
  - **Midwives**
  - **Public Health Nurses**
  - **Specialist Nurses (e.g., Pediatric, Psychiatric, Anesthetic Nurses)**

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c. Licensure Requirements

To practice legally in Nigeria, nurses and midwives must meet licensure requirements:

Education and Examination:

- Graduates from accredited institutions must pass the **NMCN qualifying examination**.
- Successful candidates are issued a **certificate of registration**.

Renewal of License:

- Licenses must be renewed every **three years**.
- Renewal requires proof of **continuing education** and CPD credits.

Foreign-Trained Nurses:

- Must undergo credential verification and may need to take an adaptation program before obtaining licensure.

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d. Disciplinary Measures for Professional Misconduct

The NMCN enforces ethical and professional standards through disciplinary measures:

Investigation of Complaints:

- Reports of negligence, malpractice, or misconduct are reviewed by the **Disciplinary Committee**.

Disciplinary Actions:

- **Warning**: For minor infractions.
- **Suspension**: Temporary revocation of the license.

- **License Revocation**: Permanent removal from the registry for severe misconduct.

Common Grounds for Disciplinary Actions:

- Gross negligence in patient care.
- Unethical behavior, such as breach of confidentiality.
- Practicing without a valid license.

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e. Continuing Professional Development (CPD)

The NMCN mandates ongoing education to maintain competence in nursing practice.

Importance of CPD:

- Ensures **up-to-date knowledge** in medical advancements.
- Improves **clinical and leadership skills**.

Requirements for CPD:

- Attendance at **recognized conferences, workshops, and refresher courses**.
- Completion of a **minimum number of CPD credits** within a licensure cycle.

4. Challenges in the Regulation of Nursing Practice

Despite structured regulations, several challenges affect nursing practice in Nigeria:

1. **Shortage of Nurses**:
    - **Brain drain** due to migration of Nigerian nurses to foreign countries.
2. **Non-Compliance with Licensure**:
    - Some nurses practice without renewing their licenses.
3. **Inadequate Monitoring**:
    - Need for improved supervision and evaluation of **training institutions**.
4. **Limited CPD Accessibility**:
    - Need for **more accessible training programs** in rural areas.

Solutions

- Strengthening **monitoring mechanisms** for compliance.
- Increasing **remuneration and incentives** for nurses to reduce brain drain.
- Expanding **CPD programs** through online and regional workshops.

Conclusion

The **Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)** is the governing body that ensures nursing and midwifery professionals uphold high standards in education, practice, and ethics. Through **regulatory frameworks**, **licensure requirements**, **continuing professional development**, and **disciplinary measures**, the NMCN safeguards the integrity of the profession. Adhering to these regulations enhances patient safety, professional accountability, and the overall quality of healthcare services in Nigeria.

Legal Rights and Responsibilities in Nursing

Introduction

Legal rights and responsibilities in nursing define the legal framework within which nurses practice. These laws ensure that nurses provide safe, ethical, and competent care while protecting both patients and healthcare professionals. Nurses must understand their legal rights to safeguard their professional practice and their legal responsibilities to prevent malpractice and ensure patient well-being.

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1. Legal Rights of Nurses

Nurses have specific rights that protect them in their professional practice, ensuring they work in a safe and just environment.

a. Right to a Safe Work Environment

- Nurses have the right to a workplace free from violence, harassment, and discrimination.
- Employers must provide adequate staffing, protective equipment, and training to prevent injuries and infections.

b. Right to Fair Compensation and Benefits

- Nurses are entitled to **fair wages, overtime pay, and benefits** as per labor laws.
- They have the right to union representation and collective bargaining.

c. Right to Professional Autonomy

- Nurses can refuse assignments that are beyond their scope of practice or pose a risk to patient safety.
- They can question unethical or illegal orders from healthcare providers.

d. Right to Protection from Legal Liability

- Nurses are protected under E**mployment and Whistle-blower Protection Laws** when they report unethical or illegal activities.
- Professional indemnity insurance helps protect nurses from legal claims and lawsuits.

e. Right to Continuing Education

- Nurses have the right to professional development and continuing education to maintain licensure.
- Employers must support nurses in attending training programs, workshops, and certification courses.

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2. Legal Responsibilities of Nurses

Nurses must adhere to legal and professional responsibilities to ensure safe, ethical, and effective patient care.

a. Duty of Care

- Nurses are legally obligated to provide competent and safe care to all patients.
- Failure to fulfill this duty can result in negligence claims.

b. Adherence to the Nurse Practice Act

- Nurses must practice within their scope as defined by the **Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)**.
- Violating the Nurse Practice Act can lead to **license revocation**.

c. Documentation and Record-Keeping

- Nurses must accurately document patient care to ensure legal protection.

- Incomplete or false documentation can lead to **legal action**.

d. Confidentiality and Patient Privacy

- Nurses must uphold **patient confidentiality** under laws like **HIPAA (Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act)**.
- Sharing patient information without consent can result in **legal penalties**.

e. Informed Consent

- Nurses must ensure patients understand the risks and benefits of procedures before giving consent.
- Patients must voluntarily agree to treatment, and nurses should witness and document the consent process.

f. Medication Administration and Controlled Substances

- Nurses must follow **legal guidelines for administering medications**, including controlled substances.
- Errors in drug administration can result in **malpractice lawsuits**.

g. Reporting Legal and Ethical Violations

- Nurses have a legal obligation to report:
    - **Abuse or neglect** of vulnerable patients.
    - **Unsafe practices** by colleagues.
    - **Infectious diseases** as required by health regulations.

h. Refusal to Participate in Unethical Practices

- Nurses can refuse to participate in procedures that violate their ethical or religious beliefs.
- However, they must transfer care to another qualified provider.

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3. Legal Consequences of Violating Responsibilities

Failure to adhere to legal responsibilities can result in severe consequences, including:

a. Malpractice and Negligence

- **Negligence** occurs when a nurse fails to provide expected care, leading to patient harm.
- **Malpractice** is negligence by a licensed professional, often leading to **legal action and compensation claims**.

b. License Suspension or Revocation

- Nurses who engage in unethical or illegal practices may face **disciplinary action** by the NMCN.
- This can result in **temporary suspension** or **permanent revocation** of their nursing license.

c. Criminal Charges

- Serious violations, such as **abuse, drug diversion, or medical fraud**, can result in **criminal prosecution and imprisonment**.

4. Case Studies and Examples

Negligence Case:

- A nurse administers the wrong medication, causing severe harm to a patient.
- The patient's family files a **malpractice lawsuit**, and the nurse loses her license.

Confidentiality Violation:

- A nurse discusses a patient's HIV status in public.
- The patient sues the hospital for **breach of confidentiality**.

Refusal of Unsafe Assignment:

- A nurse refuses to handle a complex case due to lack of training.
- The court upholds the nurse's right to refuse an assignment beyond her competency.

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5. Strategies for Legal Protection in Nursing Practice

- **Follow institutional policies** and the **NMCN Code of Ethics**.
- **Document all patient interactions** accurately.
- **Stay updated on legal regulations** and nursing laws.
- **Obtain professional liability insurance**.
- **Seek legal counsel** when involved in a lawsuit or dispute.

Nurses must understand their **legal rights and responsibilities** to protect themselves, ensure safe patient care, and uphold the **integrity of the profession**. Adhering to legal guidelines prevents **malpractice claims, disciplinary actions, and ethical dilemmas**. By following established laws and maintaining **professionalism, accountability, and ethical conduct**, nurses contribute to a safe and trustworthy healthcare system.

HUMAN RIGHTS AND PATIENTS' BILL OF RIGHTS

Introduction

Human rights and patient rights are fundamental to healthcare, ensuring dignity, respect, and ethical treatment of individuals receiving medical care. Nurses and healthcare providers are legally and ethically obligated to uphold these rights, protecting patients from discrimination, abuse, and medical negligence. Understanding **human rights in healthcare** and the **Patients' Bill of Rights** helps healthcare professionals maintain ethical standards and foster trust between patients and caregivers.

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1. Human Rights in Healthcare

Human rights are **basic freedoms and entitlements** that apply to all individuals regardless of race, gender, nationality, or socioeconomic status. In healthcare, these rights ensure access to care, dignity, and protection from harm.

a. Fundamental Human Rights in Healthcare

Right to Life and Health:

1. Every individual has the right to access healthcare services that preserve life and well-being.
2. Governments and institutions must ensure healthcare is available, accessible, and of good quality.

Right to Dignity and Respect:

Patients should be treated with respect, empathy, and without discrimination.

Right to Confidentiality and Privacy:

Personal medical information must be kept **confidential**, shared only with authorized personnel.

Right to Freedom from Harm and Abuse:

Patients should not suffer neglect, abuse, or coercion in healthcare settings.

Right to Autonomy and Informed Consent:

Patients have the right to make decisions about their care, including the right to refuse treatment.

Right to Non-Discrimination:

No patient should be denied care based on **race, gender, religion, disability, or economic status**.

Right to Participation in Healthcare Decisions:

Patients should be involved in their treatment plans and have access to second opinions.

Right to Legal Recourse:

Patients can seek justice if their rights are violated through legal complaints and lawsuits.

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2. Patients' Bill of Rights

A Patients' Bill of Rights is a set of guarantees that protect individuals receiving medical care. It outlines the expectations and responsibilities of both healthcare providers and patients.

a. Key Components of the Patients' Bill of Rights

Right to Access Healthcare:

Patients have the right to receive timely and adequate medical attention.

Right to Informed Consent:

Healthcare providers must explain treatment options, risks, and benefits before obtaining patient approval.

Right to Privacy and Confidentiality:

Patients' medical records must be protected under **data protection laws (e.g., HIPAA in the U.S., NMCN regulations in Nigeria)**.

Right to Quality and Safe Care:

Healthcare professionals must adhere to **standards of care**, ensuring safety and effectiveness.

Right to Choose a Healthcare Provider:

Patients can select their doctors or seek second opinions.

Right to Refuse Treatment:

1. Patients can decline medical procedures, including **resuscitation (DNR orders)**, based on personal beliefs.

Right to Emergency Care:

No patient should be denied care in life-threatening situations, regardless of their ability to pay.

Right to Explanation of Medical Bills:

Patients should receive clear information about their medical expenses.

Right to Voice Complaints:

Patients have the right to report medical negligence or poor treatment.

3. Importance of Human Rights and Patients' Bill of Rights in Healthcare

a. Protecting Patients from Medical Malpractice

- Upholding patient rights reduces cases of medical negligence and abuse.
- Patients have a legal basis to seek justice if harmed.

b. Enhancing Trust and Communication

- When patients feel respected, they are more likely to trust and cooperate with healthcare providers.
- Informed consent fosters shared decision-making between doctors and patients.

c. Preventing Discrimination in Healthcare

- Promotes equal treatment for all individuals, including vulnerable groups (e.g., disabled persons, elderly patients).
- Encourages ethical nursing and medical practice.

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4. Legal Framework and Enforcement

a. International Human Rights Laws

Several international organizations establish human rights principles in healthcare:

- **United Nations (UN) Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)**
- **World Health Organization (WHO) Guidelines on Health Rights**
- **International Council of Nurses (ICN) Code of Ethics**

b. Nigerian Legal and Regulatory Framework

- **Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)**: Regulates professional conduct.
- **National Health Act**: Outlines healthcare rights and obligations.
- **Nigeria Patients' Bill of Rights (2018)**: Defines patient protections in hospitals.

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5. Challenges in Implementing Patients' Rights

Despite legal protections, challenges exist in enforcing patient rights:

Limited Awareness:

- Many patients do not know their rights, leading to misuse or denial of care.

Healthcare Infrastructure Problems:

- Inadequate hospitals, staff, and funding limit access to quality care.

Cultural and Religious Beliefs:

- Some patients refuse treatments due to cultural or religious reasons, causing conflicts.

Lack of Accountability:

- Weak legal enforcement results in continued violations of patient rights.

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6. Role of Nurses in Upholding Patients' Rights

Nurses play a critical role in advocating for and protecting patient rights.

a. Responsibilities of Nurses in Patient Rights

Educating Patients on Their Rights:

- Nurses should inform patients about their entitlements and choices.

Ensuring Informed Consent:

- Before any procedure, nurses should confirm that the patient understands the treatment.

Maintaining Confidentiality:

- Patient records and personal information must be kept secure.

Reporting Abuse or Negligence:

- Nurses should **r**eport violations to authorities or hospital management.

Providing Equal and Non-Discriminatory Care:

- Treat all patients fairly and respectfully, regardless of background.

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7. Case Studies and Real-World Examples

Violation of Patient Rights:

- A hospital refuses emergency treatment to a patient because they lack payment.
- This is a violation of the right to emergency care.

Confidentiality Breach:

- A nurse shares a patient's **HIV** status with unauthorized persons.
- This breaches the right to privacy.

Informed Consent Case:

- A patient undergoes surgery without knowing the risks.
- The hospital is held liable for violating informed consent rights.

8. Strategies for Strengthening Patient Rights

- **Public Awareness Campaigns**: Educate people on healthcare rights.
- **Stronger Legal Enforcement**: Implement strict accountability measures.
- **Training for Healthcare Workers**: Ensure staff understand ethics and legal obligations.
- **Patient Feedback Systems**: Allow complaints and grievances to be heard and addressed.

Human rights and the **Patients' Bill of Rights** are fundamental in ensuring ethical, safe, and respectful healthcare. Nurses and healthcare providers must uphold these rights, ensuring patients receive equal treatment, privacy, informed consent, and quality care. By strengthening legal enforcement and increasing awareness, healthcare systems can protect patient dignity and improve healthcare outcomes.

PROFESSIONALISM IN NURSING – INTERNATIONAL AND NATIONAL ORGANIZATIONS AND MEMBERSHIP CRITERIA

Introduction

Professionalism in nursing refers to the commitment to ethical standards, continuous learning, and quality patient care. It involves adherence to professional values, accountability, and competence. Several

international and national organizations regulate and support nursing and midwifery, ensuring that professionals meet high standards of practice. These organizations provide **guidance, advocacy, training, and professional networking** opportunities for nurses and midwives.

To be part of these professional organizations, nurses and midwives must meet specific **membership criteria,** including appropriate educational qualifications, registration, and professional licensing. This lecture will cover major international and national organizations in nursing and midwifery, their roles, and membership eligibility requirements.

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1. Importance of Professional Nursing Organizations

Nursing organizations play a crucial role in advancing the profession by:

- Setting ethical and professional standards.
- Providing education and training.
- Advocating for nurses' rights.
- Improving patient care and healthcare policies.
- Encouraging research and innovation in nursing.

By joining these organizations, nurses can enhance their knowledge, develop professionally, and contribute to the advancement of the nursing profession.

2. International Professional Organizations in Nursing and Midwifery

Several global organizations regulate and support nursing and midwifery practices. These organizations promote **global best practices, research, and collaboration among nurses** worldwide.

a. International Council of Nurses (ICN)

- **Founded**: 1899
- **Headquarters**: Geneva, Switzerland
- **Purpose**:
    - Represents nurses globally.
    - Sets professional standards and ethics.
    - Advocates for improved healthcare systems.

Membership Criteria for ICN:

- ICN **does not accept individual nurses as members**.
- Membership is through **national nursing associations**, such as the **National Association of Nigerian Nurses and Midwives (NANNM)**.
- A nurse must be **registered and licensed** with the national nursing council to qualify for association membership.

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b. International Confederation of Midwives (ICM)

- **Founded**: 1922
- **Headquarters**: The Hague, Netherlands
- **Purpose**:

    - Strengthens midwifery education and practice.
    - Advocates for maternal and newborn health.
    - Establishes international midwifery standards.

Membership Criteria for ICM:

- Membership is **not open to individuals**.
- Midwives can join through **recognized national midwifery associations**.
- Must be a **licensed midwife** with a recognized qualification.

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c. World Health Organization (WHO)

- **Founded**: 1948
- **Headquarters**: Geneva, Switzerland
- **Purpose**:
    - Provides global leadership on health policies.
    - Develops guidelines for infectious disease control, vaccinations, and healthcare access.
    - Supports nursing and midwifery workforce strengthening.

Membership Criteria for WHO:

- WHO does not offer direct membership.
- It collaborates with national governments, nursing organizations, and healthcare institutions.

d. International Federation of Nurse Anesthetists (IFNA)

- **Founded**: 1989
- **Purpose**:
  - Represents nurse anesthetists globally.
  - Promotes safe anesthesia practices.
  - Develops international educational standards.

Membership Criteria for IFNA:

- Open to **registered nurse anesthetists** through national organizations.
- Requires an **advanced nursing qualification in anesthesia**.

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3. National Professional Nursing Organizations in Nigeria

In Nigeria, nursing and midwifery practice is regulated and supported by national organizations. These organizations ensure nurses maintain high ethical and professional standards.

a. Nursing and Midwifery Council of Nigeria (NMCN)

- **Regulatory body overseeing nursing and midwifery in Nigeria**.
- **Functions**:
  - Regulates education, training, and licensing.
  - Ensures nursing and midwifery practice standards.
  - Maintains disciplinary actions and ethical enforcement.

Membership Criteria for NMCN:

- Must complete nursing/midwifery education at an **NMCN-accredited institution**.
- Must pass the **NMCN** qualifying examination.
- Must register with **NMCN** and obtain a valid practicing license.
- License renewal requires **Continuing Professional Development (CPD)** credits.

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b. National Association of Nigerian Nurses and Midwives (NANNM)

- The umbrella professional association for nurses and midwives in Nigeria.
- **Functions**:
    - Advocates for nurses' welfare and rights.
    - Organizes professional development programs.
    - Represents Nigerian nurses in international organizations.

Membership Criteria for NANNM:

- Open to all registered nurses and midwives in Nigeria.
- Must possess a valid **NMCN** practicing license.
- Requires payment of annual membership dues.
- Members can participate in conferences, workshops, and union activities.

c. West African College of Nursing (WACN)

- Regional body supporting nursing education and training.
- **Functions**:
    - Conducts specialized nursing training.
    - Promotes research in nursing.
    - Certifies advanced practice nurses.

Membership Criteria for WACN:

- Must have a **Bachelor's Degree** in nursing.
- Must complete postgraduate training or specialization in nursing.
- Membership requires successful completion of **WACN** exams.

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d. Nigerian Association of Nurse Educators (NANE)

- Focuses on improving nursing education and training in Nigeria.
- **Functions**:
    - Develops nursing curricula.
    - Conducts research and training programs.

Membership Criteria for NANE:

- Open to nurses involved in teaching and academic research.
- Must hold at least a **Bachelor’s Degree** in nursing education.

4. Benefits of Professional Nursing Organizations

Being a member of professional nursing organizations provides several advantages:

Professional Development:

- Access to training programs, workshops, and continuing education.

Networking Opportunities:

- Connect with nurses, midwives, and healthcare leaders globally.

Advocacy and Legal Support:

- Protection of nurses' rights and fair working conditions.

Research and Innovation:

- Encourages evidence-based nursing practice.

Career Advancement:

- Membership can enhance job opportunities and career growth.

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5. Challenges Facing Professional Nursing Organizations

Despite their benefits, nursing organizations face several challenges:

Limited Awareness:

- Many nurses are unaware of professional organizations and their benefits.

Financial Constraints:

- Membership fees may be unaffordable for some nurses.

Weak Policy Implementation:

- Nursing policies set by organizations are not always enforced effectively.

Resistance to Professional Development:

- Some nurses do not actively participate in training and conferences.

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6. Strategies to Strengthen Nursing Professionalism

Increasing Awareness:

- Educate nurses on the importance of joining professional organizations.

Government and Institutional Support:

- Employers should support membership fees and professional training.

Stronger Enforcement of Nursing Policies:

- **NMCN** should ensure nurses adhere to professional standards.

Encouraging Continuous Learning:

- Nursing institutions should integrate **CPD (Continuing Professional Development)** programs.

Conclusion

Professional nursing organizations play a crucial role in **setting standards, advocating for nurses' rights, and promoting education**. Both international **(ICN, ICM, WHO)** and national **(NMCN, NANNM, WACN)** organizations contribute to strengthening nursing professionalism. Nurses and midwives should actively participate in these bodies to enhance their skills, knowledge, and professional development. By joining these organizations, nurses contribute to better healthcare systems and improved patient care.